

PROJECT AETHELGARD

The Master Production Bible & Game Design Document

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1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY & CORE DESIGN PILLARS

1.1 Introduction and Vision Statement

Project Aethelgard is a high-fidelity, third-person character action role-playing game designed for contemporary hardware platforms (PC, PlayStation 5, Xbox Series X). The primary creative thesis is to construct a mechanically deep character action game rooted within an authentic, dark, desaturated Anglo-Saxon and Germanic pagan mythos, distinct from the thematic aesthetics popularized by competing action-adventure intellectual properties. The narrative focuses on the utter subversion of divinity: portraying the gods not as righteous moral arbiters, but as macro-cosmic biological parasites feeding on human suffering to reverse their personal entropic decay.

The gameplay loop blends the intense kinetic weight, tactical positioning, and frame-dependent precision of contemporary heavy action games with the spatial mastery, juggling flexibility, and rapid input optimization found in classic character action titles. The user takes the role of Wulfric the Oath-Broken, an elite fallen military leader whose shattered arm has been replaced with an organic, eldritch mass known as the Wyrd-Grip. Through this mechanical foundation, the gameplay experience avoids pure power fantasy tropes, delivering instead an unyielding saga of mythic defiance, where every offensive action demands systemic calculation, high risk, and immense mechanical reward.

1.2 Core Pillars of Production

Pillar I: Visceral Impact and Weight Dynamics

Every physical contact in the Aethelgard engine must conform to strict weight distribution parameters. Hitstop windows, screen shake matrices, controller haptic frequencies, and particle emission densities are custom-tuned for every weapon tier. When a heavy strike hits flesh, the engine delays animation frames precisely to simulate resistance against bone and armor, entirely avoiding floating or floaty combat archetypes. Weapons feel heavy, dangerous, and structurally sound.

Pillar II: Systemic Resource Interdependence

The player must never find a single optimal strategy or safe combat stance. Health, Stamina, Wyrd Energy, and Poise form a continuous mathematical loop. Defensive perfection fuels offensive magic, while over-extending offensive combos leaves the player's posture completely open to devastating guard breaks.

Power comes at a severe structural cost; high-tier magical actions drain Wulfric's life capacity or escalate his vulnerability vectors, making aggressive resource exploitation a core tactical imperative.

Pillar III: Atmospheric and Narrative Authenticity

The visual and auditory landscape intentionally strips away stylized high-fantasy imagery. The environment is constructed around historic mud, dense cold rain, splintered ancient oak barriers, and tarnished iron plates. Dialogue avoids modern idioms, opting for rigid, formal, poetic structures inspired directly by historic Anglo-Saxon verse, reinforcing the bleak cosmic fatalism of a world built upon the rotting corpse of a forgotten titan.

2. COSMIC FOUNDATIONS & WORLD-CORPSE METAPHYSICS

2.1 The Myth of the World-Corpse

The baseline physics of Aethelgard rest upon a terrifying reality: the planet is dead tissue. Before the arrival of the current pantheon, the non-spatial void of the Ginnungagap harbored colossal primordial lifeforms known as Titans. The primary organism, Aurgelmir, was an amorphous network of continental biomass and neural matrices. The modern gods ambushed this entity, executing a systematic dismemberment that lasted across eons of void-time.

The mountains are the calcified remains of Aurgelmir's skeleton; the oceans are his cooling, decomposing bodily fluids. Humanity itself emerged not from divine breath, but as an accidental byproduct of this cosmic decomposition—cellular anomalies feeding on the necrotic decay of the titan. Consequently, the gods view human populations exactly as agricultural livestock: functional mechanisms designed to consolidate energy for divine harvesting operations.

2.2 The Physics of Entropic Leakage

Because Middelgard is constructed from dead tissue, the realm is subject to severe structural decay. Energy leaks constantly out into the freezing void, a phenomenon known as The Long Night. The gods are not truly immortal; they are highly advanced, long-lived biological entities who face cellular decay if their energy reservoirs empty. To maintain their golden palaces and halt their physical aging, they require human fuel. Passive prayer yields minimal energetic results; true systemic restoration requires the sudden termination of human neural networks through violent blood sacrifice, returning high-grade energy streams back to the divine processing matrices in the heavens.

3. DETAILED CHARACTER PROFILE: WULFRIC THE OATH-BROKEN

3.1 Narrative and Visual Blueprint

Wulfric is a middle-aged veteran warrior whose entire life was defined by absolute service to the state religion. Standing 6'4", his posture is slightly hunched from decades of carrying heavy iron plate. His face is heavily lined, marred by chemical burns sustained from sacred altar smoke, and his torso is covered in self-inflicted runic patterns meant to showcase devotion to the All-Father Wōden. His right arm remains human, covered in boiled leather bracers and tightly bound linen wraps. His left arm is a grotesque horror: from the shoulder down, his flesh has been replaced by the Wyrð-Grip—a mass of calcified dark oak wood, jagged exposed bone fragments, and pulsating red runic veins that throb in sync with his heartbeat.

3.2 Technical Stats and Attributes

ATTRIBUTE	BASE VALUE	SCALING FACTOR	MECHANICAL INFLUENCE
Physical Might	100	1.5x per level	Determines raw kinetic damage and poise reduction thresholds.
Wyrð Resonance	50	2.0x per level	Dictates active ability damage and energy siphon recovery rates.
Posture Integrity	120	1.2x per level	Defines maximum stagger limits before entering broken stance.
Stamina Capacity	100	1.0x per level	Governs maximum consecutive attack frames and dodge windows.

4. THE COMPLETE PARASITIC PANTHEON ANATOMY

4.1 Wōden, The Carrion Lord

Wōden is the absolute ruler of the divine harvesting network. He appears as a towering, nine-foot-tall skeleton-like entity cloaked in ancient raven feathers and tarnished silver. He lacks a left eye; in its place is a hollow socket glowing with a faint, volatile violet singularity. He carries Gungnir, a spear forged from cosmic radiation remnants that does not cut flesh, but directly disrupts atomic bonds.

Mechanical Behavior Tree Summary:

Wōden utilizes hard space-time manipulation. During his combat sequence, he can mark sections of the floor with runic glyphs. If Wulfric stands inside these areas for more than 45 frames, his spatial coordinates lock, rendering him completely unable to dodge incoming thrust attacks. The boss moves using instant positional frame offsets, requiring the player to track audio cues rather than visual trajectories to execute successful perfect parries.

4.2 Frigg, The Weaver of Chains

Frigg serves as the system coordinator for human psychological compliance. Visually, she is a multi-jointed entity featuring six distinct arms that terminate in long, needle-like metallic claws. Her face is completely obscured by an antique porcelain mask that never changes expression. She sits at the center of an expansive circular loom where the threads are literal thermal filaments stretched across the environment.

Mechanical Behavior Tree Summary:

Frigg's fight is a highly complex bullet-hell and tactical positioning hybrid. She alters the camera parameters dynamically, forcing isometric or top-down perspectives. Her main attack vectors involve launching waves of razor-sharp white-hot threads that slice through Wulfric's armor gauge instantly if crossed. She can also target the user's UI, temporarily blinding the player to their health and stamina readouts.

4.3 Tiw, The Flayed General

Tiw is the manifestation of pure militaristic cruelty. His body is entirely devoid of skin, exposing raw, blood-soaked musculature held together by heavy iron staples and silver wires. His right hand is a severed stump that continuously pumps a highly volatile, burning acidic fluid across the battlefield.

Mechanical Behavior Tree Summary:

Tiw operates at extreme speeds, keeping up relentless pressure on the player. His acidic blood creates persistent environmental hazards that permanently degrade armor values if stood upon. His attack strings are highly erratic, designed to bait premature parry attempts and break the player's posture within single combo sequences.

5. SYSTEMIC SPATIAL NAVIGATION & PHYSICS RULES

5.1 Third-Person Camera Optimization Matrix

The camera uses an adaptive spring-arm collision mechanism with a fixed focal offset. Under normal exploration parameters, the camera maintains a distance of 3.5 meters behind Wulfric's center of mass, centered slightly over the right shoulder. Field of View is default locked at 85 degrees. When a combat encounter triggers, the spring-arm dynamically extends to 5.0 meters, and the FOV opens to 95 degrees to ensure maximum lateral visibility of oncoming flanking threats.

5.2 Locomotion Frame States

- **Standard Walk Loop:** Move speed capped at 2.2 meters per second. Animation emphasizes heavy footfall with corresponding dynamic camera bob.
- **Combat Strafe Loop:** Triggered automatically upon target lock-on. Orbits the target vector at a fixed radius. Left-to-right velocity adjustments feature a 4-frame blend space to simulate realistic weight transitions.
- **Sprint State:** Requires holding the assigned input modifier. Acceleration curve takes 12 frames to hit peak velocity of 6.8 meters per second. Stamina is consumed at a rate of 5 units per second.
- **Evade Roll / Phase Shift:** Initiating a dodge awards exactly 12 frames of absolute invulnerability (i-frames) starting on frame 1. Total animation length is 28 frames. Recovery frames (13-28) carry a 1.5x damage multiplier if hit, penalizing poor spatial evaluation.

6. FRAME-ACCURATE ATTACK MATRIX & INPUT LOGIC

6.1 Oathsliver Input Sequence Layout

All primary offensive maneuvers using Wulfric's shattered great-axe (Oathsliver) are bound to a strict deterministic frame configuration to guarantee competitive-grade precision and responsiveness. Designers and programmers must adhere strictly to the following core animation data sheets:

ATTACK ACTION	INPUT COMMAND	STARTUP FRAMES	ACTIVE FRAMES	RECOVERY FRAMES	POISE DAMAGE VALUE
Light Horizontal Sweep (L1)	RB / R1	8 frames	4 frames	12 frames	15 units
Heavy Overhead Cleave (H1)	RT / R2	18 frames	6 frames	24 frames	45 units
Sundering Leaping Strike	Forward + RT	26 frames	8 frames	32 frames	70 units
Whirlwind of Ash (Hold)	Hold RB	12 frames	Continuous	18 frames	8 units per tick

6.2 Attack Modification and Cancel Mechanics

To maximize skill ceiling expression, players can execute "Parry-Canceling" during the startup phase of any Light Attack string. If an enemy initiate a counterstrike during frames 1 through 7 of Wulfric's Light Horizontal Sweep, pressing the Block input instantly overwrites the current action state, transitioning Wulfric directly into an active Parry frame window. Heavy attacks cannot be parry-canceled; once a heavy overhead cleave passes frame 10 of its windup, the player is fully committed to the animation sequence, accentuating the risk-reward matrix of high-damage choices.

7. THE WYRD-GRIP MECHANISM & RUNIC ABILITY TREE

7.1 Biological Parasitism Architecture

The Wyrd-Grip acts as Wulfric's primary conduit for supernatural mechanics, powered directly by his internal Wyrd Energy gauge. This gauge is strictly replenished through offensive martial success—every successful axe hit and perfect defensive execution generates kinetic and magical back-flow that charges the arm. However, the arm is an invasive entity; utilizing high-tier runic spells scales a passive "Corruption Level" meter. When Corruption hits max capacity, Wulfric drops into a volatile "Blood-Drunk" frenzy state where his offensive velocity increases by 50%, but his physical life force degrades linearly by 3% per second until an enemy is executed.

7.2 Technical Mechanics of Core Active Abilities

The Tether Hook (Off-Hand Action)

Pressing the assigned off-hand modifier launches a calcified wood tendril along a forward ray-cast vector up to 15 meters. The engine evaluates the target's structural mass variable:

```
if (Target.Mass < Player.Mass) {
    Target.Velocity = CalculatePullVector(Player.Position, Target.Position);
    Target.SetState(Stunned, 1.5s);
} else {
    Player.Velocity = CalculateLaunchVector(Target.Position, Player.Position);
    Player.SetState(AirborneAttackReady);
}
```

This simple conditional evaluation transforms the Tether Hook into an immediate gap-closing tool against bosses or an isolation utility mechanism against high-priority ranged spellcasters.

Runic Extraction

When an elite enemy is brought below a 25% health threshold or enters a total posture break, Wulfric can execute a Runic Extraction. The Wyrd-Grip physically pierces the entity's chest cavity, draining its

elemental code. This temporary modification alters Oathsliver's properties for 20 seconds, wrapping the blade in volatile assets like divine lightning (adding localized chain-damage arrays) or obsidian stone (granting continuous passive poise armor during attacks).

8. POISE MECHANICS, STAGGER MATRICES & EXECUTION SYSTEMS

8.1 Poise Calculation Engine Formulas

Every entity within the game world possesses an active Poise Threshold value (P_v) that dictates behavioral interruption rules. Unlike health, poise regenerates rapidly if the entity avoids taking damage for a contiguous 3-second window. The mathematical formula for poise reduction per hit scales based on weapon velocity, charge duration, and combo positioning modifiers:

$$\text{P_Reduction} = \text{Base_Poise_Damage} * (1.0 + \text{Charge_Duration_Seconds}) * \text{Combo_Multiplier}$$

When an entity's P_v reaches zero, the current animation loop immediately breaks. The character model switches into a unique, highly vulnerable "Kneeling" or "Stunned" skeletal state, disabling all active defensive tracking arrays for a fixed 4-second duration.

8.2 Visceral Execution Design Rules

Approaching a staggered entity and pressing the Interact key initiates a cinematic execution phase. During an execution, Wulfric and the targeted enemy are granted absolute immunity frames against external environmental hazards or secondary enemy damage vectors to preserve presentation quality. Executions are highly kinetic, showing the violent use of both Oathsliver and the Wyrld-Grip to dismantle enemy anatomy. Mechanically, completing an execution instantly triggers a resource refund script, returning 15% of missing health and 50% of maximum stamina to Wulfric, structurally reinforcing an aggressive, high-risk playstyle.

9. NINE REALMS REGIONAL FLOW & STRUCTURAL LEVEL GDD

9.1 Structural Level Architecture Design Rules

Levels in Project Aethelgard eschew the vacant layout of open-world structures and the restrictive confinement of simple corridor tracks, employing a curated "Wide Linear" architecture topology. Each zone features a clearly defined cinematic primary critical path, but expands laterally into extensive optional exploration spaces, puzzle chambers, and hidden high-threat sub-boss arenas. Level designers must maintain strict pacing guidelines: a standard zone must integrate a structured sequence consisting of an introductory exploration track, an initial ambush chokepoint, a specialized environmental navigation block, a secondary shortcut unlock vector, and a final landmark boss stadium.

9.2 Detailed Breakdown of Key Production Zones

Zone I: The Ash-Mire (The Outskirts of Middelgard)

The introductory level of the game. Visually dominated by toxic, low-hanging gray fog, shallow black swamp waters, weeping willow trees, and mass sacrificial trenches. Pacing here is slow, focusing on establishing the baseline rhythmic weight of combat. The environment acts as an extended mechanical tutorial, teaching the player to navigate deep muck that limits movement speeds, use the Tether Hook to pull down environmental structural anchors, and engage the basic undead thrall archetypes.

Zone II: The Ironwood Ridge

A vertical, treacherous mountain pass built along the massive, petrified roots of an ancient primordial world tree cluster. The environment requires the extensive utilization of Wulfric's Wyrd-Grip to climb shear rock faces and swing across deep mountain chasms. Hazards include falling shale, high-velocity wind currents that physically alter jump trajectories, and specialized fortresses manned by elite human zealots who launch burning tar pots from defensive battlements.

Zone III: The Gilded Sanctum (The Heavenly Processing Facility)

The ultimate layer of the divine infrastructure. Unlike traditional glorious heavenly locations, the Gilded Sanctum is a sterile, horrifying processing plant where human souls are mechanically distilled into raw kinetic power for the gods. The floors are constructed from highly polished white marble slick with ongoing blood channels. The architecture transitions into grand, disturbing golden halls filled with

massive humongous processing vats, ticking celestial gears, and floating runic sentinels that guard the high-tier divine throne rooms.

10. GRAND LEVEL-BY-LEVEL NARRATIVE SCRIPT & DIALOG ASSETS

10.1 Cinematic Prologue Script Excerpt

The narrative presentation utilizes a locked, close-proximity cinematic camera that never cuts away during major transitions, keeping the user completely embedded within Wulfric's spatial viewpoint.

[SCENE START]

EXT. THE ALTAR OF ASH - NIGHT

DENSE, ICY RAIN HAMMERS DOWN ON AN ELEVATED STONE PLATFORM.

WULFRIC IS KNEELING, HELD DOWN BY FOUR IMPERIAL GUARDS.

HIS FACE IS COVERED IN MUD AND BLOOD.

IN FRONT OF HIM STANDS THE HIGH PRIEST, CLAD IN RAVEN SILKS.

THE BODIES OF EADGYTH AND OSRIC LIE PARALYZED ON THE ALTAR COLD STONE.

HIGH PRIEST

The sky-fire ice turns to ash, Wulfric. The All-Father demands the marrow of your marrow to ignite the sun. Your oath demands their blood.

WULFRIC

(Voice raspy, heavy breathing)

I carved your shrines... I slaughtered the western tribes... I gave forty winters of blood to the high sky. Take my flesh. Leave the boy.

HIGH PRIEST

A warrior's flesh is spent marrow. Only innocence holds the pristine code to halt the entropic freeze.

THE HIGH PRIEST LIFTS A SACRED OBSIDIAN DAGGER.

WULFRIC ROARS, BREAKING HIS RIGHT HAND FREE FROM THE GUARD'S GRIP, BUT A VALKYRIE SENTINEL INSTANTLY DROPS FROM THE SKY, HER BLADE FLASHING.

WULFRIC'S LEFT ARM IS SEVERED AT THE ELBOW. BLOOD SPURTS ONTO THE MUD.

HIGH PRIEST

You are Oath-Broken. Throw the carcass into the Miasma Pit. Let the worms

resolve his treason.

WULFRIC IS KICKED VIOLENTLY BACKWARDS, FALLING INTO THE INKY BLACKNESS OF THE CHASM AS THE BLADE DESCENDS ON THE ALTAR.

[SCENE END]

10.2 Chapter 3 Interaction Script: The Awakening

Following his catastrophic fall, Wulfric wakes at the bottom of the world-corpse chasm, surrounded by absolute dark. This marks the first real-time control transition.

WULFRIC

(Gasping, clutching his stump)

Cold... everything is cold. Let the dark take it. Let the freeze end.

THE CORE OF THE UN-MAKER (VOICE REDUX OVER CONTROLLER SPEAKER)

End? No. The ledger is open, butcher of the hearth. Their skin is smooth in their golden halls while your seed rots in the soil above. Do you wish to sleep, or do you wish to tear down the stars?

WULFRIC

Give me... a weapon.

THE PROSTHETIC MASS ERUPTS FROM THE SOIL, ROOTING INTO HIS ARM STUMP WITH SEVERE FORCE. WULFRIC ROARS AS THE RED RUNES IGNITE.

11. COORDINATED ATTACK-TOKEN AI ARCHITECTURE

11.1 The Attack-Token Distribution Management System

To completely prevent the chaotic visual clutter, overlapping unblockable indicators, and cheap off-screen deaths that compromise lesser action games, the combat engine enforces a strict Attack-Token Distribution Management System. Enemies surrounding Wulfric do not think or attack independently; they are regulated by a central combat manager script running in background threads. The architecture categorizes and dispenses two primary classes of tokens:

- **Melee Attack Tokens:** Default quantity capped at 2. Only two enemies in close-quarters proximity can execute active strike strings simultaneously. Other surrounding melee combatants automatically drop into low-aggro positioning behavior, circling the player and maintaining defensive spacing.
- **Ranged / Disruptor Tokens:** Default quantity capped at 1. Only a single ranged asset can cast homing projectiles or initiate battlefield hazard logic at any given moment, ensuring the player can use clear audio indicators to calculate dodge offsets.

11.2 Dynamic Threat Level Adjustments

When Wulfric transitions into a high-tier combo ranking (Rank S or higher), the central AI manager automatically increases token availability variables, scaling enemy attack frequency by 35% and allowing smart flanking AI pathfinding arrays to activate. This creates a highly responsive difficulty curve that mirrors the player's immediate skill execution level.

12. TECHNICAL BESTIARY & COMBAT PROFILES

12.1 The Husked Thrall (Fodder Class)

The basic resurrected soldier corpse. They possess minimal health pools and highly predictable, wide wind-up horizontal strikes. Their primary design purpose is resource farming; they are deliberately slow to allow the player to build up combo multipliers, safely refill Wyrd energy strings, and easily execute posture-breaks to secure vital health recovery drops mid-encounter.

12.2 The Valkyrja Sentinel (Elite Specialist Class)

High-agility, winged mechanical-biological hybrids. They hover continuously at an altitude of 4 meters, completely out of normal axe swing reach. Their behavioral pattern involves sudden, high-speed aerial dive-bombs that break standard blocking stances. The player must wait for the definitive red unblockable glint, execute a precise side-dodge, and instantly fire the Tether Hook to grapple the Valkyrie, slamming her violently into the dirt where her defense value drops to zero.

12.3 The Ettin Juggernaut (Brute Class)

Massive 10-foot-tall deformed stone giants wielding monumental blocks of raw iron. They possess total super-armor during all startup frames, meaning light attacks will not interrupt their actions. They demand the strategic deployment of Tier 3 Charged Heavy axe strikes to crack their outer armor layering, or perfect parries to deplete their massive poise meters and force a vulnerability state.

13. PROGRESSION MATH, ECONOMY BALANCE & SKILL UPGRADE LOOPS

13.1 Economy Currencies

Progression relies entirely on two clean, physical resources harvested directly from combat engagement metrics, completely avoiding abstract menu point systems:

- **Ashen Marrow:** Extracted from standard and elite enemy corpses. Used at forge anvils to upgrade Oathsliver's damage output scaling and modify raw physical statistics.
- **Divine Ichors:** Siphoned directly from defeated major gods and sub-bosses. Acts as the rare catalyst required to unlock major brand-new nodes on the Wyrd-Grip runic ability matrix.

13.2 The Skill Progression Matrix Blueprint

[Oathsliver Base Level] ---> Marrow Invested ---> [Tier 2 Shattered Edge] ---> [Tier 3 Shattered Edge]
[Wyrd-Grip Unlocked] ---> Ichor Invested ---> [Path of the Devourer] ---> [Path of the Devourer]
---> Ichor Invested ---> [Path of the Void-Walker] ---> [Path of the Void-Walker]

Each major milestone node requires a specific structural trial to unlock; for instance, to master the Phase Shift Teleport, the user must successfully complete an arena challenge without taking a single unparried physical blow, ensuring that upgrade gates correspond directly to actual player mechanical mastery.

14. MINIMALISM HUD LAYOUT & ERGONOMIC INTERFACE RULES

14.1 Diegetic Screen Philosophy

To ensure maximum immersion within the dark fantasy landscape, the user interface remains entirely hidden during non-combat exploration segments. The camera lens remains completely uncluttered by persistent health containers or mapping tools. When Wulfric enters a combat state or receives structural damage, the essential interface elements elegantly slide into view in the top-left corner, featuring desaturated historical rune frames:

- **The Crimson Track (Health Bar):** Displays actual structural health pool. Features a 500ms trailing lag meter to visualize exactly how much damage was sustained during a heavy blow.
- **The Rune String (Wyrd Energy):** A collection of distinct glowing nodes that ignite as energy is built up. Expending energy to launch active runic spells extinguishes these nodes from right to left.
- **Off-Screen Indicators:** A clean high-contrast vignette halo around Wulfric's feet that flashes bright white for incoming basic attacks or volatile red for unblockable incoming maneuvers originating outside the direct field of view.

15. ENGINE OPTIMIZATION, MEMORY ALLOCATION & ASSET BUDGETS

15.1 Real-Time Asset Streaming & Memory Optimization

To preserve a continuous, cinematic seamless experience without visible loading screens, the level data layout utilizes strict memory budgeting guidelines. Levels are carved into operational streaming volumes separated by physical squeeze spaces or heavy structural doors that take exactly 4.5 seconds to interact with. During these interaction windows, the engine unloads previous regional structural assets from the VRAM allocation pool and initiates asynchronous streaming of the upcoming zone's texture arrays.

15.2 Poly-Count and Performance Targets

ASSET TYPE	MAXIMUM POLY BUDGET	TEXTURE MAP RESOLUTION	LOD STEPS COUNT
Wulfric Protagonist Model	175,000 polygons	4K PBR Master Material	5 distinct steps
Major Boss Entities (Wōden/Thunor)	250,000 polygons	4K PBR Multi-UV Set	6 distinct steps
Standard Environment Props	15,000 polygons	2K Texture Arrays	3 distinct steps

The target platform code profile must achieve a locked 60 frames per second at dynamic 1440p resolution within Performance Mode configurations, ensuring fluid execution of frame-dependent combat loops across all targeted next-gen platform architectures.